



HASSAN AMMAR Associated Press
RESIDENTS wave a flag picturing Hezbollah's leader while returning to Zefta, Lebanon, as a ceasefire began.

Angelenos' outlook turns glum

In an annual UCLA survey, L.A. County residents' view of their quality of life reaches its lowest point in a decade

BY GRACE TOOHEY

A decade ago, Los Angeles County was facing serious economic and social challenges, but residents felt “generally lukewarm” about their quality of life.

But lukewarm turned out to be L.A.'s high point.

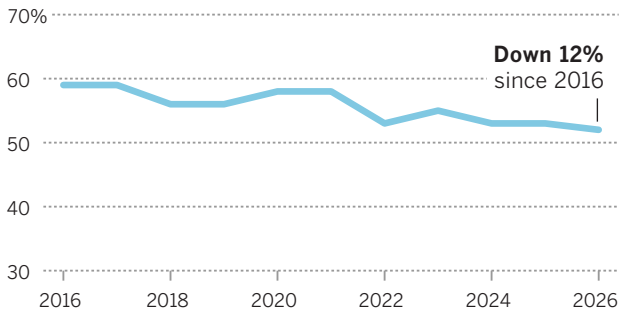
As the years went on, Angelenos have continued to report falling satisfaction across key indicators — in particular, cost of living, traffic and education. This year, the county's overall quality-of-life ranking dropped to the lowest point in one survey's 11-year history.

This year's record-low Quality of Life Index, a metric compiled by UCLA's Luskin School of Public Affairs, builds on a decline that accelerated rapidly during the height of the COVID-19 pandemic and has struggled to rebound, as L.A. County residents have faced several disasters and crises — devastating wildfires and destabilizing immigration raids — on top of some of the world's highest housing costs.

“We've been through a lot in the last five years: COVID, increases in the cost of living, immigration sweeps, and the Altadena and Palisades fires. [They all] have taken their toll on virtually every aspect of our lives,” said Zev Ya- [See Survey, A9]

L.A. County residents report decade-low quality of life satisfaction

UCLA researchers derive the annual Quality of Life Index based on resident surveys ranking key metrics, such as cost of living, traffic and education.



Los Angeles Initiative at the UCLA Luskin School of Public Affairs
GRACE TOOHEY Los Angeles Times

D4vd is arrested in killing of teen

BY RICHARD WINTON, CLARA HARTER AND SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

Singer D4vd was arrested Thursday on suspicion of murder in connection with the case of a missing teenage girl whose decomposing body was discovered inside his Tesla in Hollywood.

David Anthony Burke, 21, was taken into custody shortly after 4:30 p.m. in Hollywood, said Los Angeles Police Department Capt. Scot Williams. It is not clear what specific evidence led authorities to arrest Burke. Records show he was formally booked into the LAPD 77th Street Station jail hours later, at 10:12 p.m.

He is being held without bail and the case will be presented to the L.A. County district attorney's office Monday for filing consideration, according to the LAPD. Burke's attorneys released a statement Thursday emphasizing that the singer had not yet been charged and noting that they intend to mount a vigorous defense.

“Let us be clear — the actual evidence in this case will show that David Burke did not murder Celeste Rivas Hernandez and he was not the cause of her death,” Blair Berk, Marilyn Bednarski and Regina Peter said in a joint statement.

Photos of Thursday's arrest shared by the LAPD showed members of the [See D4vd, A9]

Redefining the donor state

In their bid to flip the Senate, Californians pour money into Democratic campaigns elsewhere

BY BEN WIEDER AND GABRIELLE LAMARR LEMEE

WASHINGTON — Democrats who once saw retaking the U.S. Senate as a long shot in 2026 have newfound hope thanks to an unpopular president and a California donor machine that has snapped into action.

Californians provided the most out-of-state cash to Democrats in nearly every hotly contested race, and in several cases gave more than in-state donors, according to a Times analysis of campaign finance filings covering the first three months of 2026.

Sen. Jon Ossoff of Georgia, who took in more than \$14 million overall, received nearly as much from California backers as from supporters in his home state among donors who contributed at least \$200 and whose identities were disclosed.

James Talarico, a Democratic Senate candidate in Texas, has raised a stagger-

ing \$27 million so far this year, with California donors contributing just under \$1.2 million to back his campaign — second only to Texas supporters among those donors whose names were disclosed.

Donors who give less than \$200 are not required to be identified in campaign finance reports and made up a significant share of the donors to Ossoff's and Talarico's campaigns.

Republicans currently have control of the Senate with 53 of the chamber's 100 seats. This year 35 seats are at play, including special elections in Florida and Ohio.

Although more of the seats up for grabs are in Republican hands, polling showing the potential for tight races in several of them has given Democrats [See Donors, A8]

A Rolls, a bear suit and a car insurance ripoff

BY SUMMER LIN AND HANNAH FRY

“Operation Bear Claw” was definitely a new kind of insurance fraud case.

The target: a Rolls-Royce and two Mercedes-Benzes.

The weapon: a bear suit and meat claws.

A Southern California woman and two men, who pleaded no contest this week in a scheme to rip off insurance companies by putting on a bear costume and staging fake attacks on luxury vehicles, have been sen-

tenced to jail time.

The scam was strictly small-time. Insurance companies lost a total of \$141,839. But authorities said it represented a highly unusual take on car insurance fraud that was uncovered only when an investigator from one of the insurance companies took a careful look at surveillance video of one of the orchestrated attacks.

“It's definitely out of the ordinary,” said Capt. Eric Hood, a 20-year veteran with the California Department of Insurance who led the [See Fraud, A9]

Emerging deal would provide Iran with major concessions

U.S. claims strait is open for good. Tehran says it may shut it again, impose tolls.

BY MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Upbeat claims from President Trump over an imminent peace deal to end the war with Iran were met with deep skepticism Friday across the Middle East, where Iranian and Israeli officials questioned the prospects for a lasting agreement that would satisfy all parties.

The outlines of an agreement began to emerge that would provide Iran with a major strategic victory — and a potential financial windfall — allowing the Islamic Republic to leverage its control over the Strait of Hormuz to exact significant concessions from the United States and its ally Israel as Trump presses for a swift end to the conflict.

In a series of social media posts and interviews with reporters, Trump announced that the strait was “fully open,” vowing Tehran would never again attempt to control it. But Iranian officials and state media said that conditions remained on passage through the waterway, including the imposition of tolls and coordination with the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps.

Iranian diplomats posted threats that its closure could resume at any

time of their choosing, and warned that restrictions would return unless the United States agreed to lift a blockade of its ports. Trump had said Friday that the blockade would remain in place.

“The conditional and limited reopening of a portion of the Strait of Hormuz is solely an Iranian initiative, one that creates responsibility and serves to test the firm commitments of the opposing side,” said a top aide to Iran's president, dismissing Trump's statements on the contours of a deal as “baseless.”

“If they renege on their promises,” he added, “they will face dire consequences.”

In an overture to Iran, Trump said Israel would be “prohibited” from conducting additional military strikes in Lebanon, where the Israeli government of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu seeks to prevent Hezbollah, an Iranian proxy militia, from rearming, a potential threat to communities in the Israeli north.

But in a speech delivered in Hebrew, Netanyahu would say only that Israel had agreed to a temporary ceasefire, while members of his Cabinet warned that Israel Defense Forces operations in southern Lebanon were not yet finished. A top ally of the prime minister at a right-wing Israeli news outlet warned that Trump was “surrendering” to Iran in the talks.

It was a day of public messaging from a president [See War, A4]

California's high gas prices push gig drivers off the road

BY QUEENIE WONG

The highest gas prices in the country are making it tougher for some gig drivers to make a living.

Gas prices have shot up amid the war in the Middle East. On average, California gas prices are the most expensive in the United States, according to data from the American Automobile Assn. The average price of regular gas in California is almost \$6. The national average is a little above \$4.

While Uber and Lyft drivers have concocted clever ways to cut gas consumption, they say that without some relief they will be forced to leave the ride-hailing business.

John Mejia was already struggling to make money as a part-time Lyft driver when soaring gas prices made his side hustle even harder.

“Unfortunately, it's the economics of paying less to drivers and gas prices,” he said. “It actually is pulling

people out of the business.”

Gig work offers drivers the freedom to work for themselves and more flexibility, but being independent contractors also means they must shoulder unexpected costs.

Ride-sharing companies say they're trying to help, but drivers say the gas relief comes with caveats. For now, drivers say they're being pickier about what rides they accept, cutting hours and are looking at other ways to make money.

Mejia, who started driving for Lyft more than a decade ago, said in his early days, he would sometimes make \$400 in three hours. Now it takes 12 hours to rake in \$200.

The San Francisco Bay Area consultant is an active member of the California Gig Workers Union, so he knows he isn't alone. California has more than 800,000 gig rideshare drivers, according to the group, which is affiliated with the Service [See Rideshare, A12]

Sheinbaum seeks diplomatic thaw

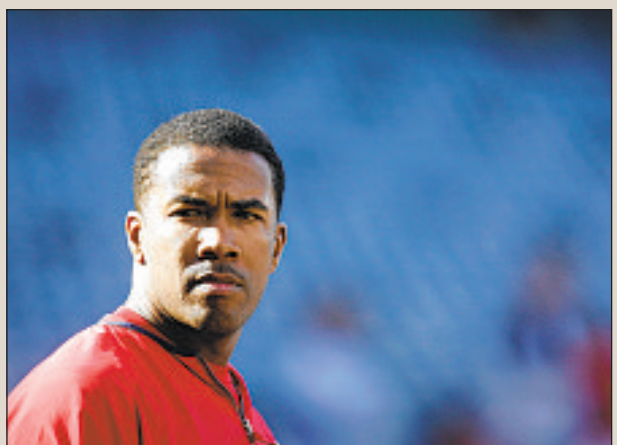
Mexican president is visiting Spain to show solidarity with leaders and to ease simmering tensions. **WORLD, A2**

Dust storms steal Coachella's mojo

Researchers say environmental hazards cost the U.S. billions of dollars annually and could worsen. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Partly sunny; warm. L.A. Basin: 82/60. **B8**



ROBERT LACHMAN Los Angeles Times

EX-ANGELS SLUGGER DIES

Garret Anderson, the even-keeled outfielder who hit a key double in Game 7 of the 2002 World Series, suffers a heart attack at 53. **SPORTS, B12**